

The authority stack

Which standards govern a documentation deliverable, in the order they override one another — and how likely each is to be in force at NIWC Pacific. The tiers matter more than the entries: an argument about a style guide never beats a contract data requirement.

NIWC / SPAWAR USAGE KEY	
ESTABLISHED	Routine at NIWC Pacific or its SPAWAR predecessor. Assume it applies.
LIKELY	Probable on a program of this type. Confirm early.
SITUATIONAL	Depends on whether the program has hardware, safety, or fielded-manual scope.
UNLIKELY	Belongs to a different community. Know it; do not assume it.

TIER 1 Contract documents

These outrank every style guide in the document. A style preference never overrides a CDRL requirement.

STANDARD	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS	NIWC / SPAWAR
CDRL / DD Form 1423	The list of what you owe and when. If it is on here, it is a contract obligation, not a courtesy.	ESTABLISHED Every contract deliverable flows from it.
DI-IPSC-81443A Software User Manual	Tells a hands-on user how to install and run a CSCI. Prescribes section order and content.	ESTABLISHED Office of primary responsibility is N/ SPAWAR — NIWC's own predecessor owns this DID.
DI-IPSC-81442A Software Version Description	What is in this build, what changed, what is still open.	ESTABLISHED Standard on Navy software deliveries.
DI-IPSC-81441A Software Product Specification	The as-built record of the delivered software.	LIKELY Common where the government takes maintenance responsibility.
DI-IPSC-81446A Computer Operation Manual	How to operate the machine the software runs on, as distinct from the software itself.	LIKELY Applies where the delivery includes the platform.
DI-IPSC-81428 Software Installation Plan	How the software reaches the site and gets stood up.	LIKELY Standard for fielded C4ISR software.
DI-IPSC-81429 Software Transition Plan	How support hands off from contractor to government.	SITUATIONAL Appears near end of a development phase.
Program SCG Security Classification Guide	Decides what is classified, what is CUI, and what may be released. Not a writer's judgment call.	ESTABLISHED Every program has one and it governs absolutely.

TIER 2 Prose style authority

Governs voice, usage, and mechanics. Subordinate to Tier 1 on anything the DID specifies. The second group below is not a style authority for this contract — it is where the platform's own terminology decisions are already written down.

STANDARD	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS	NIWC / SPAWAR
Microsoft Writing Style Guide	The de facto standard for software documentation. Free, online, opinionated about UI terminology and procedures.	LIKELY The usual choice in a software-heavy shop. Best guess for the editorial authority here.
Chicago Manual of Style	The general-purpose fallback for whatever the technical guide does not cover.	LIKELY Almost always the named secondary.
GPO Style Manual	The federal government's own house style — capitalization, abbreviation, official titles.	SITUATIONAL Cited more in civilian agencies than in Navy C4ISR.
Google developer documentation style guide	Newer software-industry alternative to Microsoft. Free and well maintained.	UNLIKELY Rare in federal work; more common commercially.
Contractor internal style guide	The corporate layer stacked on whatever the contract names.	LIKELY Usually exists and usually goes unmentioned until day one. Ask for it.
ASD-STE100 Simplified Technical English	Controlled vocabulary plus 65 writing rules. Built for aircraft maintenance procedures read under pressure.	UNLIKELY An aviation-maintenance standard. Rarely required on software programs — though the discipline transfers.
PLATFORM TERMINOLOGY SOURCES — THE RED HAT AND IBM FAMILY		
IBM Style	The primary style authority for all Red Hat product documentation since the IBM acquisition. Available to Red Hat employees online; not in wider circulation. The published <i>IBM Style Guide</i> covers most of the same ground.	UNLIKELY Not a contract authority here — but it is the upstream rule set behind every RHEL document the team reads.
Red Hat supplementary style guide for product documentation	Public, CC BY-SA. Overrides or supplements IBM Style. Consultation order is product-specific guide, then this, then IBM Style. Carries a glossary that settles platform terminology — firewall, IPv4, MAC address, network bond, network team, TCP, UDP.	SITUATIONAL The best free authority for how to refer to RHEL components consistently. Worth adopting for terminology even where it is not the style guide.
Red Hat Technical Writing Style Guide	Covers Red Hat training and certification content and everything outside product docs. Punctuation and grammar, common mistakes, translation and global-audience strategy, content design, and a word usage dictionary. Public and open source.	SITUATIONAL Useful as a secondary reference and as a model for writing a program style guide from scratch.

STANDARD	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS	NIWC / SPAWAR
Modular Documentation Reference Guide Red Hat	Red Hat's content model: concept, procedure, and reference modules, implemented in AsciiDoc. Structurally the same topic types as DITA concept, task, and reference.	SITUATIONAL Strong reference for structuring a doc set on a Red Hat-heavy program, and it points at the tool in front of them rather than at DITA in the abstract.
Vale at Red Hat tooling, not a standard	An open-source prose linter with Red Hat's rule set. Checks writing against style rules automatically, in CI, on every commit.	SITUATIONAL Not a requirement anywhere — a proposable process improvement. Style findings get caught in the pipeline instead of in human review.

TIER 3 Military format and technical manual standards

In force only where the deliverable is a technical manual for a fielded system rather than software documentation.

STANDARD	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS	NIWC / SPAWAR
MIL-STD-38784	General style and format for technical manuals — page layout, front matter, numbering, warnings.	SITUATIONAL Applies if any hardware or fielded-system manual is in scope.
MIL-STD-40051	The Army's IETM authoring standard.	UNLIKELY Wrong service. Appears only around joint programs.
MIL-STD-1472	Human engineering design criteria, including how warnings are presented to an operator.	UNLIKELY Cited by engineering more often than by documentation.
S1000D	International specification for IETM data modules and the CSDB that holds them.	UNLIKELY NAVAIR and platform programs, not C4ISR software.

TIER 4 Safety and hazard classification

Decides whether a statement is a warning, a caution, or a note. That is a safety determination, not a formatting choice.

STANDARD	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS	NIWC / SPAWAR
MIL-STD-882E	System safety. Defines severity and probability categories, which drive hazard wording.	SITUATIONAL In force where the system has a safety case.
ANSI Z535.6	Safety information in product manuals. Defines the DANGER / WARNING / CAUTION / NOTICE hierarchy.	SITUATIONAL Often adopted by reference in a style guide rather than by contract.

TIER 5 Security documentation

These are content formats, not style guides. The structure comes from the accreditation system, not from an editor.

STANDARD	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS	NIWC / SPAWAR
NIST SP 800-53	The security control catalog. Security documents are written against control language.	ESTABLISHED Foundation of every DoD accreditation package.

STANDARD	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS	NIWC / SPAWAR
DoDI 8510.01 Risk Management Framework	The process that determines what must exist before an authority to operate is granted.	ESTABLISHED Governs every fielded DoD system.
eMASS artifact templates	The government system dictates the shape of the SSP, SAR, and POA&M.	ESTABLISHED Where the security deliverables actually live.
DoDI 5200.48 32 CFR Part 2002	Controlled Unclassified Information. Banner marking, designation indicator, handling and transmission rules.	ESTABLISHED The posting states all deliverables are CUI.
DISA STIG / SRG	The structure any configuration-hardening guidance follows, and the compliance target it is written against.	ESTABLISHED Directly relevant given the Red Hat and SELinux emphasis.

TIER 6 Mandatory federal, routinely skipped

Legal requirements that generate findings precisely because nobody treats them as style rules.

STANDARD	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS	NIWC / SPAWAR
Section 508 WCAG 2.1 AA	Accessibility of electronic content. Alt text, real table headers, tagged PDFs, no text inside images.	ESTABLISHED Required by law for federal deliverables. Frequently the first audit finding.
Plain Writing Act plainlanguage.gov	Federal plain-language mandate and the guidelines that implement it.	SITUATIONAL Required in principle, loosely enforced on technical deliverables.

TIER 7 Content standards cited more than followed

Useful vocabulary for a review meeting. Rarely a contractual obligation.

STANDARD	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS	NIWC / SPAWAR
IEEE 1063	Software user documentation — what a user manual is required to contain.	UNLIKELY Superseded in practice by the DID.
ISO/IEC/IEEE 26511-26515	Managing, designing, testing, and assessing information for users.	UNLIKELY Academic reference rather than contract requirement.
DITA 1.3 (OASIS)	Topic-based structured authoring. The concepts underpin how any single-source tool organizes content.	SITUATIONAL Valuable as a mental model even where the tool is MadCap Flare.

On the usage column. These are informed estimates from standard practice in Navy C4ISR documentation, not verified facts about any particular program. The single verified entry is the Software User Manual DID, whose office of primary responsibility is N/SPAWAR. Confirm the rest against the contract before relying on any of it.

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